

Diploma in Leadership and
Management

**It's all about
the skills**



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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of upskilling and reskilling. Students will also receive essential information regarding active listening and running effective meetings as part of the skills for this lesson.

Introduction

It's all about the skills, we've covered competencies in module 1 and now we're going to look at skills and upskilling. This lesson will also focus on active listening and running an effective meetings skill.

Key reading materials:

<https://www.westvalley.com/resources/employer-resources/top-five-best-stress-management-tips-for-managers>

Skills of the future:

According to (Top University , n.d.) here are the following skills that the workforce will need in the future.

Cognitive flexibility:

Employees of the future will need to be mentally flexible. Employees will need to be open to change and they will need to ability to manage their own actions and emotions. Multi-taskers will be highly valued and employers will seek out these individuals.

Digital literacy and computational thinking:

As the world continues to rely on highly technical and continuously evolving technologies, the need for those with the digital skills to match also increases. You've most definitely heard of STEM, but have you heard of SMAC (social, mobile, analytics and cloud)? Although it may seem like we're being bombarded with digital buzzwords, being digitally literate offers capabilities beyond what was once thought possible when it comes to emerging technologies, such as artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning, Internet of Things (IoT), and data science. "We need to train scholars to deal with the challenges of the 21st century, some which we may not yet have encountered," says Professor Adam Habib, Vice-Chancellor and Principal of the University of the Witwatersrand.

Emotional and social intelligence:

For everything that can be replaced by digital technologies and artificial intelligence, emotional and social intelligence remain uniquely human capabilities.

In some sectors, these qualities are absolutely crucial. The demand for jobs in healthcare, for example, are on the increase – demonstrating how some roles will always require a human element. Your future job is more than likely going to include working closely with others, so having empathy, the ability to collaborate, as well as excellent communication skills is something you're most definitely going to need. (Lukins)

Creative and innovative mindset:

Much like having an excellent sense of social intelligence, natural creativity is something which can't be easily replicated by the latest digital technologies. As long as you can think outside the box, you'll be just fine. (Lukins)

How to Get Employees Needed New Skills

Please note that these exercise, examples and insight is provided by OPM.gov.

Now that the Planning phase is complete, it is time to implement reskilling or upskilling. The Implementation phase involves the identification of strategies to close gaps, plans to implement the strategies, and measures for assessing strategic progress. It also involves communicating progress and strategies on a regular basis. The Implementation Model has four components: Define Focus, Implement, Measure, and Communicate. Implementation Model Define Focus
Implement Measure Commuincate

- Define Focus
- Confirm goals, strategies, and policies.
- Identify the occupations with skills gaps
- Identify the occupations requiring reskilling or upskilling
- Identify the approach to reskilling or upskilling and closing skills gaps
- Create an action plan

Implement Implement

Reskilling or upskilling strategies and policies in the agency using an action plan with a measurable timeline.

Measure

Measure and monitor agency's reskilling efforts using a timeline that shows progress against milestones. Evaluate and revise for continuous improvement, and make adjustments as necessary to address issues or corrections to change reskilling approach.

Communication

Communication is key to success. Communicate clear goals, progress, strategies, and engage with agency departments to ensure continuous and ongoing improvement on reskilling the workforce. Ensure a common change language is used to describe and discuss the program.

Example Reskilling and Upskilling Approaches

BLENDED TRAINING	Training that requires two or more methods of delivery, which must be completed in order to satisfy the educational requirements.
CAREER PATH	A progression of positions in one or more occupational series.
COACHING	Partnering with individuals in a thought-provoking and creative process that inspires them to maximize their personal and professional potential.
DETAIL	A temporary assignment of an employee to a different position for a specified period, with the employee returning to his or her regular duties at the end of the assignment. A detail assignment implies that there is a vacant position available for the candidate to occupy which requires a Standard Form 52 preparation and submittal through proper channels.
MENTORING	A process that focuses specifically on providing guidance, direction, and career advice. It is usually a formal or informal relationship between two people – a senior mentor (usually outside the protégé's chain of supervision) and a junior protégé.
ON THE JOB TRAINING	Formal methods/activities planned and structured to promote learning by doing, e.g., detail assignments/programs.
ROTATIONAL ASSIGNMENT	Developmental assignment away from an employee's current position. During these assignments, individuals learn to adapt and successfully lead in a new position.
SHADOWING ASSIGNMENT	Observing a Federal leader in daily activities for a defined period of time. By watching leaders in action, the program participant gains exposure to leadership duties, responsibilities and approaches, and observes how concepts learned are applied in real-world situations.

Action Plan Example

This is an example of a completed action plan. A template can be found in Appendix B.

Reskilling/Upskilling Action Plan	
Reskilling/Upskilling Initiative: Electrical Engineers Increasing the number of Electrical Engineers at the Government Mechanical Office (GMO) by reskilling employees currently employed as General Engineers, Industrial Engineers, and Mechanical Engineers. The reskilling initiative will include career development for Electrical Technicians to transition to Electrical Engineers	Date: October 30, 2018
Describe the trigger for Reskilling and/or Upskilling? (Mandate, major change in workforce agency, employee need/desire, automation, etc.) What is the problem being addressed? GMO is downsizing its workforce from 7,000 to 3,000 employees due to a change in mission. To maintain productivity, GMO plans to cross train (reskill) all employees that work in mission critical occupations versus hire new employees.	
Describe the objectives and goals of the Reskilling/Upskilling initiative? 1. Reskill entire workforce to ensure adequate knowledge, skill, and ability to complete the agency's mission successfully. 2. Reskilling effort will cross train employees for two or more occupations in their career field. 3. Build a pipeline of qualified employees for leadership positions. 4. Establish a sustainable process for reskilling at GMO and include it in the agency's strategic plan for succession planning.	
Describe the barrier, problem, or deficiency being addressed: GMO's average workforce age is 50. The practice of performing more than one job at GMO is uncommon and often a task given to employees in the special pay category. GMO's goal is to close skill gaps in ALL of the STEM occupations by fiscal year 2021.	
Describe what is causing the barrier/problem (i.e., What is the root cause?): Most employees are reluctant to change and accept additional work assignments without an increase in pay and benefits. Managers fear the workforce reduction will leave GMO with employees who are near retirement or who lack the interest to learn a new occupation under reskilling.	
Define success or the desired outcome upon completion of Reskilling/Upskilling: GMO communicates to employees the change in organizational structure and job duties. The agency is able to reduce the workforce size from 7,000 to 3,000 using VERA/VSIP authorities, agency transfers, voluntary retirements, and resignations without any consideration of a reduction in force process. The 3,000 employees are successfully reskilled for one or more occupations in their career field over a multi-year process with the help of the HR department and GMO's training office. GMO successfully closes skill gaps in ALL STEM occupations.	

Reskilling Toolkit

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Active listening

According to (Norma, n.d.) "Something I recently used with great success for getting the message across about Active Listening is below:

- Group split into pairs, A & B
- Take Bs out of the room and ask to wait outside
- Inform the As that whilst they are listening to their partner, everytime their partner says something that evokes their 'inner voice' i.e. they want to ask a question, makes them think about something etc... they put their hand up for five seconds then put it back down.
- Ask them to do this for the entire conversation - As are not allowed to interact with Bs, ask questions, affirm understanding etc.. As remain silent, just raising their hand everytime their inner voice kicks in.
- Next inform the Bs outside that they are to speak to As about something of interest, an experience, their last holiday anything positive that has happened to them in the last six months. They have three minutes to talk.
- Ask Bs back into the room, then allow three minutes of talking from Bs.
- At the end of the three minutes ask the Bs how they felt whilst talking to A, emotions evoked etc... general answers back are normally 'didn't feel listened too, didn't understand why they were putting their hand up, lost my train of thought because they obviously weren't listening,' etc...

You can also ask the As to not only raise their hand, but also lose focus, i.e. start staring out the window, become transfixed with the detail on their partner's jacket, etc...another obvious distraction to their listening.

It's a great simple, quick exercise to run, and then to talk with the group about the power of active listening afterwards.

You can run the exercise again, this time allowing the As to interact, ask questions, become involved in the conversation etc... and compare the two conversations, which was more satisfying etc..."

Skillswise

Mandie suggested some free resources from Skillswise: <http://www.bbc.co.uk/skillswise/words/listening/> including factsheets, worksheets and activities.

Active listening skills

K.Shankar Ram adds: "After asking the group to do an exercise as recommended (A & B) I do this which brings out the importance of listening:

- I ask all the members to write the names of three people whom they consider as good listeners. I personally check with each participant if they have written three names (some find it difficult) then I ask the group if anyone has written the name of the person whom they don't like. Usually nobody writes the name of the person whom they don't like.
- Then I ask if the three people they have written, come in any one of these categories: liked by them, loved by them or respected by them. The response normally is yes. Even if someone writes the name of the person whom they don't like, that person will come in the group of people respected by the participant.
- Now I ask them, if they are to be liked or loved or respected by others, how should they be?
- They see the point that they need to be good listeners if they are to be liked, loved or respected by others."

Round Robin exercise

'graham.fear' advises: Delegates are given a topic to discuss.

At various points the trainer says 'stop', at which point the next delegate in line must continue the last delegates sentence starting with their last few words.

Once the group gets the hang of this, instead of following the same pattern (1 to 2 to 3 to 4 to 1 etc) the trainer names who has to continue next part of the statement, forcing all delegates to listen closely to what everyone is saying instead of just the person before them.

"Though some of the delegates may not like this exercise, I feel that its a good one, as it tests product knowledge while also promoting active listening. Initially all groups started somewhat shakily, but with the exception of one person everyone picked up the idea quickly and were able to do the task, and a marked improvement in responses and flow was seen as the exercise went on. As a group exercise it can be fun, and even competitive, and after a good smoothly completed topic there was an obvious sense of achievement and satisfaction."

Presentation

Rus says:

"If you want to test the listening skills of delegates then you could try a two minute "presentation" followed by eight minutes of theory "lecture".

Then ask the delegates to recall as much of the two minute presentation as they can.

You will have ten minutes to draw out their recollections and to assess why they remembered bits and why they forgot bits (the "lecture" is only there to provide them with some opportunity to forget).

Interestingly you will probably be able to include the visual signals that aided memory/understanding...listening with their eyes..."

A time you weren't listened to

Derek suggests:

"Ask people to think of a time when they felt they weren't listened to (could be work, family, doctors, shopping etc)

Split into pairs and share stories, the listener must try and identify 2 things: what the person in the story did that demonstrated non-listening and what impact this had on the speaker (usually they feel devalued, angry, upset, hurt).

To debrief you can gather all the ideas together and develop some principles of good listening by reversing what happened in the stories."

Bus driver exercise

'Belly1' says: "This can be used as an ice breaker or a listening exercise..."

Tell the group that you will be asking questions on what they are about to hear and that they can take notes if they wish.

Start by saying you are the bus driver.

You then read out a bus route, for example: You are the bus driver at stop no 1, three people got on the bus, one of them was wearing a red hat.

At stop 2, four people got on and one got off.

At stop 3, two people got on, one person was carrying a bag and the person with the red hat got off.

Continue with this detailed theme.

When you have finished you ask the question: What is the bus drivers age? The majority of people will not have heard the opening line: "you are bus driver".

Meeting agenda templates:

4 essential elements of a meeting agenda

- Purpose: Why you're calling the meeting. Basically, justify the existence of your meeting in one sentence.
- Before the meeting: Any homework people need to complete in order for the meeting to run effectively and efficiently.
- Agenda: What will occur during the meeting and in what order, with time estimates.
- Outcomes: What will be completed or facilitated as a result of the meeting.

Meeting/Project Name:			
Date of Meeting: (MM/DD/YYYY)		Time:	
Meeting Facilitator:		Location:	

1. Meeting objective

2. Attendees

Name	Department/Division	E-mail	Phone

3. Meeting Agenda

Topic	Owner	Time

4. Pre-work/Preparation (documents/handouts to bring, reading material, etc.)

Description	Prepared by

Automate meeting updates with prosperforms.com

Submitted by:

Meeting Minutes

Meeting/Project Name:			
Date of Meeting: (MM/DD/YYYY)		Time:	
Minutes Prepared By:		Location:	

1. Meeting objective

2. Attendees			
Name	Department/Division	E-mail	Phone

3. Meeting Agenda		
Topic	Owner	Time

4. Action Items		
Action	Owner	Due date

5. Next meeting (if applicable)			
Date: (MM/DD/YYYY)		Time:	Location:
Objective:			

References

- Inc. . (n.d.). Boost your networking skills . Retrieved from Inc. : <https://www.inc.com/amarillo/seven-ways-to-up-your-networking-game.html>
- Norma, B. (n.d.). Trainers' Tips: active listening exercises. Retrieved from Trainingzone : <https://www.trainingzone.co.uk/develop/cpd/trainers-tips-active-listening-exercises>
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